Monika Kirloskar-Steinbach, Comparative Philosophy as a Philosophy of Practice[1]

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The framework of my paper will be set by understanding comparative philosophy as a philosophy of practice. Accordingly, I will reflect on the practice of doing comparative philosophy by engaging with two closely related methodologies of comparison. Both approaches call on comparativists to pay greater attention to the practices on the ground; yet they differ in their ramifications. Using the notion of political freedom in the South Asian context as a lens, I will argue that both these methodologies are warranted for, depending on the context of comparison.

I. Introduction

In the next 20 minutes, I will single out two closely related methodologies of comparison for a detailed, critical analysis. In this regard, I will draw on the work of Sudipto Kaviraj and Sheldon Pollock to substantiate my claims. Using the philosophy of practice as a lens, I will work out how these methodologies differ in their ramifications. To do so, I will begin with a general understanding of political freedom and examine whether and how, a proponent of these methodologies would reconstruct its meaning in the Indian context. I will endeavor to show that there is no reason to favor one over the other. A philosophy of practice must accommodate both these methodologies in circumstances appropriate to them.

Before I proceed, allow me to quickly sketch the specific understanding of the term 'philosophy of practice', which sets the framework of this paper. Generally put, a philosophy of practice attributes a certain primacy to the very act of philosophizing. It closely attends to the context in which this practice is carried out as well as to the impact this practice could, and does, have on the lives of those affected by it. It does not seek to develop one single, abstract and true, theoretical model which alone can capture the panoply of differing practices. A philosophy of practice is instead more of a reflective stance on what is being practiced under the guise of theory. At the outset, let me state that within the scope of this paper I will not be able to illustrate the close relation between comparative philosophy and a philosophy of practice. I understand comparative philosophy as the moral attitude which underscores the importance of a fair standard of comparison in the study of texts, positions, traditions, etc.

II. Political Freedom: Two Approaches

Let us begin with the notion of political freedom. If one were to operate with the conceptual cluster associated with the idea of political freedom found in standard philosophical introductions, notions like moral freedom, conceptions of the good, powers of deliberation, the ability to take up responsibility for one's actions, rationality, reasonability, the social context of choice-making would all belong to the conceptual cluster associated with political freedom. They would be utilized to argue, for example, that every instantiation of political power should be such that it can be morally justified. Can an understanding of political freedom, which operates with this conceptual cluster, guide a comparative philosopher in her work? Or should she rather concentrate on understanding the specific language of freedom spoken by a particular polity assuming that such a language can indeed be found in it?

My surmise is that we will not find a unanimous answer even amongst those present here. For the purposes of my paper, allow me to separate 'self-conscious universalists' from 'radical contextualists'. Self-conscious universalists would not categorically deny that similar ways of understanding political freedom can in principle be found in differing cultural contexts. Their work towards a 'plural grounding' of ideas and concepts is driven by their assumption that similar ideas could develop in different cultural contexts. This is why their position can be termed 'universal'. However, the qualifier 'self-conscious' is highly significant. When such scholars hold that they have enough ground to believe that a specific concept or idea recurs in a different place and possibly at a different time, their position is marked by a high degree of cautiousness. Strictly speaking, it is contextual, and tentative. They advocate such a qualified 'universalism' only when contextual studies warrant that certain similarities between understandings embedded in specific, different contexts can reasonably be posited. In working out the idea of political freedom in non Anglo-European contexts, it is very likely that our 'self-conscious universalist' would in some ways implement some features of the conceptual cluster mentioned above.

'Radical contextualists' on the other hand would underscore a highly detailed study of understandings germane to a particular context. Ideally, such a study can be carried through only when this context is isolated from other similar ones. In this process, these thinkers would take utmost care that they do not utilize ideas which in any sense can be considered to be exogenous. Radical contextualists believe that notions like political freedom are time and place specific. Cross-cultural exercises, in which one particular understanding of political

freedom is applied (whether wholly or partially) to diverse cultural contexts, are, to say the least, a barren exercise.

I would now like to focus on the South Asian context (more specifically on the Indian one) to bring to the fore key differences in both these approaches. As is well-known, independent India's constitution attributes a whole package of rights and duties to its citizens. However, it is commonly held that especially its Hindu philosophical traditions do not sit well with the concept of political freedom. The Indian context, thus, seems to offer a rich testing-ground for our methodological reflections.

III. Search for Political Freedom in the Indian Context

Self-Conscious Universalists

So how would a self-conscious universalist and a radical contextualist go about engaging with political freedom in India? We can anticipate that in her exploration our 'self-conscious universalist' will not shy away from using the conceptual cluster (or parts thereof) mentioned above. She is open to the possibility that a thorough study of the Indian situation could disclose some similarities with this general understanding. Moreover, since discourses and institutions were strongly reconfigured during this struggle for power under colonization, it is highly likely that she will study personalities involved in the movement for independence, like for example Gandhi, Tagore, Radhakrishnan, Ambedkar. She will furthermore not filter out the thought of those personalities who are commonly said to have leaned heavily on sources exogenous to the Indian tradition. In addition, our 'self-conscious universalist' will probably proceed to analyze other relevant documents and practices in the colonial and pre-colonial periods in her attempt at understanding political freedom in the Indian context.

Many aspects which I deem relevant for a 'self-conscious universalist' can be found in Sudipto Kaviraj's work on political freedom.[i] Kaviraj (cf. 2002) sets himself the task of searching for an understanding of this freedom in modern India. Notably, he does not explicate this idea. In fact, he seems to presume that there is a shared understanding of how this freedom is conceived. Kaviraj's search is guided by the following methodological questions: Is there a practical concept or cluster in earlier Hindu intellectual traditions? How was the concept of political freedom, if this is homogenous at all, introduced in the Indian context? How does this concept work on the indigenous counterpart it seeks to display,

discredit or undermine (2002: 100)? Referencing textual sources like the Arthasastra and the Manusmirti as well as utilizing the practice of caste, Kaviraj concludes that in pre-colonial India "freedom of choice in vital matters was not just limited, but conceptually absent" (2002: 103). The concept of freedom in currency was other-worldly; it underscored the overcoming of this life through religious salvation. Like other authors working on this field, he is struck by how this older understanding was —slowly but surely —partially replaced by a new, more mundane understanding of social and political freedom. The earlier understanding of freedom from a this-worldly life continued to exist side-by-side with newer understandings; vernacular speakers distinguished between the two uses by differentiating the use-context (2002: 104).

Kaviraj underscores that the colonial regime did not introduce political institutions of liberalism (2010: 17).[ii] In fact, it brought in economic and social rights to make "the economic part of the social world tractable and amenable to its control". Salient colonial institutions of property-holding, of education, and of intellectual influence paved the way for the development of a discourse on political freedom (2002: 105). Indians soon perceived that the rationalist discourse introduced by the colonialist regime to stabilize its imperialistic hegemony, could be turned against it (2010: 71). What began as "rationalist disputations about the grounding of religious beliefs" (2002: 114), led to an overhaul of the contemporary social structure. The development of the concept of individualism tailor-made for the Indian context, led to religious reformist societies like the Brahmo Samaj, which understood itself as a collectivity of free individuals who chose to belong to it (2002: 116). The struggle for social freedom from predominant understandings undergirded the call for political freedom as evident in the writings of Tagore, Gandhi and Nehru (2002: 121). This set-up led to disputes on religious freedom; freedom of expression and of the press followed in its wake.

Kaviraj's 'self-conscious universalism' is palpable. Although the colonial transformation of knowledges was as he says an "epistemic rupture on the vastest possible scale", he openly searches for the concept of political freedom in modern India by implementing all the resources at his disposal (2005: 132).[iii] In drawing out the becoming of political freedom in contemporary India, he displays how this notion took on another trajectory as supposedly taken in the Anglo-European tradition.

In his work, Kaviraj concentrates on the complex translation-processes in which Indian reformers in the colonial period attempted to engraft this concept of political freedom on indigenous parallels (2002: 108). He illustrates how indigenous concepts pertaining to political freedom like *rajyaniti* and *rajyadharma,* which operated with natural differences in the attribution of political status and power, were retranslated by these reformers. In the process, they broke through the "immense conceptual barrier of viewing politics as an exclusive elite activity of ruling society (2013: 34).[iv] *Rajyaniti*, which in its original connotation dealt with the kingly rules of just power, has today come to signify the political arena which is open to all of India's citizens. The change in meaning initiated by these thinkers was fomented by the making of the Indian constitution, which changed the "network of social practice" (2013: 36).

Kaviraj's work on political freedom also brings to light another crucial aspect of a 'self-conscious universalist' mentioned above, namely the possibility that instantiations of political freedom could differ from context to context. As he notes, the distinction between negative and positive liberty is replaced in the Indian context by the distinction between the freedom of individuals and communities (2002: 97). Furthermore, despite the change of connotation, the current use of political freedom, which is partially based on the indigenous understanding of *rajyaniti* could possibly carry "some debris of its pre-modern meanings and practical associations" (2013: 37).

Remarkably, Kaviraj does not attempt to reconstruct *the* language of political freedom spoken by all of India's citizens. "The political world of modern India is a complex configuration of different ways of being political — in which officials try to invoke the older practical language to extend their power, subaltern individuals or groups sometimes accept it by acquiescing to it, and at times try to resist this illegitimate extension of power by invoking modern institutional rules. A concise history of this complex, multi-layered world lies inside the language that people use to describe this world and to navigate through its surprises" (Kaviraj 2013: 37). Kaviraj, it can be said succeeds in, to use his own words, "expand our cognitive vision to see how these liberal ideas moved across different parts of the world, to quite different fates" (2013: 25-26). Let us now turn to the radical contextualists and their take on the notion of political freedom in the Indian context.

Radical Contextualists

Radical contextualists too would argue that political freedom had no intellectual precursors in pre-colonial India (Pollock 2005: 88). Till the advent of the British, the intellectual legacy of pre-colonial Hindu India did not attempt to correlate its understanding of metaphysical freedom with socio-political freedom, as we, comparative philosophers, understand it today.

Unlike their counterparts, it is highly doubtful whether radical contextualists would embark on the search for political freedom in the Indian context at all. One possible reason would be that they perceive a focus on reconfiguration processes played out during and after colonialism as being deeply problematic: These processes negatively affected the intellectual framework of those subjected to it. Precisely these reconfigurations, they would say, led the latter to break away from their own moorings and, thus, rupture their bonding with their intellectual and ancestral forebears. The stage was set for as some authors call it, a 'fetishization of liberal individualism' (Pollock et al. 2008: 581).[v]

Sheldon Pollock's work exemplifies the issues I would like to associate a 'radical contextualist' with. Pollock's main complaint with this present paper would be that even the rough conceptual cluster sketched above skews comparison inasmuch as it brings into play pre-concepts and pre-judgments. And as long as these play any role in the process of comparison, he argues, we will not sufficiently be able to "perceive what may be different about the relation of culture and power at other times and places" (Pollock 1998: 44).[vi]

Pollock argues that a pre-set, analytical model is a kind of "intellectual imperialism", however outdated that term may have become (1998: 43). One applies a conceptual framework immanent to one context on another and cannot but search for imitations there.[vii] In his own work, he seeks to suspend this very model in order to avoid the "epistemological trap" set by this brand of imperialism. Instead of substituting this model with another analytical counterpart, he sets himself to a "deep empirical scholarship" which works out the differences such that the universalization of any European particular can be offset (Pollock 1998: 68, 48).

Pollock searches for a methodology which will allow one to reconstruct pre-modern worlds in their own light, without using a conceptual lens familiar to us, and exogenous to the context in question. Warning about any kind of "conceptual apriorism", which attempts to pre-structure our experience, he seeks to break away from standard hitherto paradigms of studying pre-modern worlds (2006: 178).[viii] The bare rudiments of his framework can be

expressed in very simple terms: A context becomes meaningful by capturing all salient moments immanent to it. However, it is imperative that these moments are understood individually and somehow independently of each other (2010: 198).[ix]

Pollock, let it be noted, is not antagonistic towards comparisons per se. His main point seems to be that the prevalence of a conceptual hegemony in the humanities occludes a thorough, and differentiated, view of the material at hand. This hegemony is sustained by a habitualized use of universal, pre-set frameworks, without sufficiently reflecting on whether they are indeed applicable to the contexts to be examined. In this regard, the theory of theory, so to say, is deeply deficient and must be overhauled. We must learn to make room for manifold understandings and instantiations of ideas. "[N]o given model of intellection can be held to be universal" (2010: 190).

Pollock rightly notes that the academic must in a comparison try to focus on the context at hand without relating her object of comparison to ideas and notions familiar to her because of her own cultural background. We must seek to reconstruct other conceptual worlds which are not merely comprehensible to us and our readers because of their relation to conceptual frameworks dominant in our own discourses. In this regard, it does make sense to concentrate on the context at hand, without always seeking for a cross-culturally valid invariable. The use of precisely such invariables slides into a will to dominate the other context especially when, for example, its study throws up details which are completely unfamiliar to the person studying it. In such a case, we either suppress these differences or interpret them as deviations of our own framework.

Like Pollock, Kaviraj too strives to work on a standard of comparison in which this process is free of hegemony. He too canvasses for a conceptual autonomy which would allow for a just reconstruction of the context at hand. In addition, Kaviraj also seeks to strike a new path in the study of South Asian political thought. In his writings on political freedom, one can discern his urge for a plural grounding of political freedom. He would advocate that political freedom be grounded in different contexts with the help of immanent materials. Despite being embedded in diverse contexts, these groundings could possibly resemble each other in salient ways.

In my reading, Pollock would probably target the self-conscious universalist's entry-point itself: Any attempt at entering the conceptual universe of freedom (political or otherwise) in

the Indian context through modern India can only yield partial and unsatisfactory results. Due to this 'faulty' start, a comparativist will dig herself deeper into the faulty, dominant paradigms she seeks to overcome. A satisfactory, conceptual study of freedom in the Indian context, on the other hand, would have to begin with pre-modern materials and work through how they, if at all, influence current understandings in this context. Indeed, Pollock's critique of standardized comparisons and his call for conceptual autonomy, stand on firm ground. Unless we come away from entrenched paradigms of comparison, we cannot embark on a new journey in which we learn to a make better sense of the past.

But does this mean that a self-conscious universalist should abandon her own methodological framework and join camp with her cousin, the radical contextualist? Allow me to sketch why this need not necessarily be the case. As mentioned in the Introduction, one characteristic of a philosophy of practice is that it attends to the way theories impact upon the concrete lives of those influenced by them. Today, many polities, including those with histories of colonization, have constitutions which implement notions of political freedom. To be able to comprehend the impact of this freedom on the self-understandings of those subjected to it, it does seem feasible to use a methodological framework similar to the one adopted by the self-conscious universalist. Furthermore, a philosophy of practice demands of its practitioners that they do not position themselves as impartial and unmoved spectators, who hover above the social practices they investigate. In fact, as "reflective participants" (Bohman) in societal debates, they occupy the same dialogical space as the informed public. If, thus, issues of political freedom become virulent in a certain context, a philosopher would not be able to claim that her methodological framework does not allow her to engage with modern notions like political freedom (Tully 2002: 551). In fact, this understanding of philosophy urges her to involve herself in societal debates, help clarify, and enrich extant practices through reflection.

To recapitulate: Within the framework set up a philosophy of practice, I began by asking whether the conceptual cluster associated with political freedom can in any way be implemented by comparative philosophers like the self-conscious universalists and radical contextualists. Although both share the view that models and intellectual trends dominant in Anglo-European philosophy can only become strait-jackets when they are forcefully imposed upon non Anglo-European contexts, the former would advocate a study of cross-cultural conceptual and ideational, migratory flows in determining the trajectories of concepts and

ideas; the latter, it seems, would prefer to begin in the past and work towards the present. More precisely, their attention seems to be principally cast on how pre-modern intellectual resources shaped, and continue to influence, contemporary contexts of our times. This paper has attempted to advance the thesis that depending on the context both these methodologies are warranted for in developing narratives which ground political freedom.

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[i] S. Kaviraj, ‚Ideas of Freedom in Modern India', in H. R. Taylor (ed.), T*he Idea of Freedom in Asia and Africa,* Stanford (USA), 2002, pp. 97-142.

[ii] S. Kaviraj, *The Imaginary Institution of India*, New York 2010.

[iii] S. Kaviraj, ‚The Sudden Death of Sanskrit Knowledge', *Journal of Indian Philosophy*, Vol. 33, 2005, pp. 119-142.

[iv] S. Kaviraj, ‚On the Historicity of 'the Political': Rajaniti and Politics in Modern Indian Thought', M. Freeden (ed.), *Comparative Political Thought: Theorizing Practices*, London etc.: Routledge, 2013, pp. 24-39.

[v] S. Pollock, H. Bhabha, C. A. Breckenridge, D. Chakrabarty, Editorial 'Cosmopolitianisms', *Public Culture*, Vol. 12, No. 3, 2000, pp. 577-589.

[vi] S. Pollock, 'India in the Vernacular Millennium: Literary Culture and Polity, 1000-1500', *Daedalus*, Vol. 127, No. 3, 1998, pp. 41-74.

[vii] Or „fluent lisping imitation[s]" as Kaviraj (2013: 381) calls them. S. Kaviraj, Why is the Mirror Cracked?, *Comparative Studies of South Asia, Africa and the Middle East,* Vol. 33, No. 3, 2013, pp. 380-391.

[viii] S. Pollock, "Empire and Imitation", in C. Calhoun, F. Cooper, and K. Moore (eds.), *Lessons of Empire,* New York: New Press, 2006, pp. 175-188.

[ix] S. Pollock, "Comparision without Hegemony", in H. Joas, and B. Klein (eds.), *The Benefit of Broad Horizons: Intellectual and Institutional Preconditions for a Global Social Science", Festschrift för Björn Wittrock on his 65th. Birthday*, Leiden and Boston: Brill, 2010, pp. 185-204.